

securities—and that the majority are usually spectacularly wrong in a much shorter time than that.

Still, he is not a liar; nor is our other friend. They are both subject to the wishful delusions of the child, who cannot bear to believe anything that is too unpleasant. But we expect a child to grow up and learn what is reality, as opposed to what are merely his passionate hopes.

This, however, is asking too much of your romantic Wall Streeter—and they are all romantics or they would never have chosen this business, which is a business of dreams. They continue to dream of conquest, coups, and power, for themselves and for the people they advise.

Some Wall Street men manage to shed these, given sufficient years. But the ultimate dream they almost never shed: that there is a secret, with meaning, in the rise and fall of financial enterprises—that a “close study” of this and that will prove something; that it will tell the initiate when there will be a rally or give the speculator a better than even chance of making a killing or guarantee for an estate a safe 4 per cent for a few generations. All these things are demonstrably unpredictable, but the truth is too bitter to look at with open eyes.

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*No Wall Streeter is willing to be just a croupier. He insists that he is also a prophet, a scholar, and a magician with money.*

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If this business is a meaningless business, what is going to become of these men who are in it?

I am not speaking of just their livelihood, which is probably at its lowest ebb right now. (There *I* go.) For the tongues of neither men nor angels can keep the public out of Wall Street, once prices are up and booming.

The real menace is to their self-respect. If a man cannot be an authority on his own trade, on what *is* he going to be an authority?